



RAMSAY DE GIVE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Anti-vaccine views harden in Texas

BY FENIT NIRAPPIL

SEMINOLE, TEXAS — When the local hospital warned of a brewing measles outbreak, Kaleigh Brantner urged fellow residents of this rural West Texas community to beware of vaccinating their children.

Two weeks later, her unvaccinated 7-year-old son came home from school with a fever. The telltale rash across his body followed. But his mild symptoms and swift recovery only hardened Brantner's anti-vaccination convictions, even after an unvaccinated child died of measles at a hospital 80 miles away.

"We're not going to harm our children or [risk] the potential to harm our children," she said, "so that we can save yours."

Texas's worst measles eruption in three decades has surged to 146 known cases, with the true toll likely much higher, exposing how under-vaccinated communities are unnecessarily vulnerable to one of the world's most contagious diseases, experts say. The first known victim was 6 and otherwise healthy, according to two individuals with knowledge of the case who

In West Texas, the death of a 6-year-old amid a surge of measles cases has spurred hundreds to immunize their children — while others have only grown more resistant

spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss details that haven't been publicly released.

The life-threatening outbreak in West Texas starkly illustrates the stakes of slipping immunization rates and the ascension of vaccine skeptics, including Secretary of Health and Human Services Robert F. Kennedy Jr., to the highest levels of the public health establishment.

And it has revealed how fear and the scientifically false claims of the anti-vaccine movement have seeped into communities such as Gaines County, the epicenter of the outbreak, hardening attitudes about vaccines, pro and con, in the face of a

dangerous, preventable disease.

Brantner, 34, said she decided not to vaccinate her children after years of her own research and because, she said, her nephew had a severe reaction to the vaccine against diphtheria, tetanus and pertussis. She moved from New Mexico to Texas in part because it's easier here to claim an exception to school vaccine mandates.

"A cough, runny nose, fever and rash to a healthy child is mild but vaccine adverse reactions are severe!!!" she commented on Jan. 30 on the local hospital's Facebook post, which described measles symptoms.

Brantner's son Paxton recovered from measles with little problem, she said, after she fed him organic food and cod liver oil, bathed him in magnesium salts and rubbed him in beef tallow cream infused with lavender. The family took precautions to protect others in the community, such as ordering groceries for pickup and keeping their older son out of school. He developed a measles rash Friday.

Medical experts and the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention say harm from

SEE MEASLES ON A16

DOGE layoffs at nuclear agency touch off crisis

SCRAMBLE TO FIND, REHIRE SAFETY CHIEFS

Agency oversees security of 5,000 U.S. warheads

BY EVAN HALPER
AND HANNAH NATANSON

Amid the tumult of mass firings, the Trump administration's dismissal of workers who maintain America's nuclear weapons delivered perhaps the greatest shock. These are people with highly sensitive jobs, the Energy Department would later acknowledge, who should have never been fired.

Almost all the workers were rehired in an embarrassing about-face, a prominent example of how the administration has had to reverse dismissals in multiple instances where its scatter-shot approach caused deeper damage to agencies than anticipated.

The employees of the National Nuclear Security Administration are stewards of a sprawling government system that keeps 5,000

nuclear warheads secure and ready. They make sure radiation doesn't leak, weapons don't mistakenly detonate and plutonium doesn't get into the wrong hands.

Yet late the night before Valentine's Day, the Trump administration perfunctorily fired 17 percent of the National Nuclear Security Administration's workforce, over the strenuous objections of senior nuclear officials.

"The president said workers critical to national security would be exempt from the firings. But then there was an active decision to say these positions are not critical to national security," said an official at the nuclear agency, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to avoid reprisals. "It is so absurd I don't even know what to say."

The episode proved to be among the biggest blunders of

SEE DOGE ON A6

Entitlement programs pose big test for Trump

President tries to avoid political third rails as GOP eyes Medicaid cuts

BY DAN DIAMOND

President Donald Trump has insisted — loudly and repeatedly — that his administration won't cut Medicare, Medicaid and Social Security.

"I have said it so many times, you shouldn't be asking me that question," Trump told reporters Wednesday, invoking President George H.W. Bush's famous campaign promise in 1988 to not raise taxes. "This will not be 'read my

lips.' It won't be 'read my lips' anymore: We're not going to touch it."

Yet Bush ultimately broke his promise and raised taxes, and Trump may also find it difficult to keep his pledge not to touch the three entitlement programs that provide benefits to more than 130 million Americans.

Social Security, Medicare and Medicaid represent more than 40 percent of the federal budget — and a major focus of the Trump administration's operation to cut government spending, with billionaire entrepreneur Elon Musk saying that the three programs represent major sources of waste, fraud and abuse. Republicans also concede that Medicaid, the

SEE BUDGET ON A4

World leaders rally around Zelensky

BY STEVE HENDRIX
AND MARIANA ALFARO

LONDON — Rattled European leaders on Sunday said they were "doubling down" on supporting Ukraine and boosting military aid following the televised Oval Office blowup between President Donald Trump and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky.

The embattled Zelensky was greeted with cheers outside 10 Downing Street and a warm hug from British Prime Minister Keir Starmer when he arrived late Saturday for an emergency summit of European leaders. The

London summit boosts support for Ukraine after Oval Office blowup

pair embraced again at the start of the session Sunday, which Starmer described as a "once-in-a-generation moment" for European security, and they sat side-by-side during the talks.

The display of support stood in stark contrast with comments Sunday from Trump administration officials, who heaped blame

on Zelensky for the White House uproar. National security adviser Michael Waltz described Zelensky's behavior as "incredibly disrespectful," and Secretary of State Marco Rubio accused him of disrupting U.S. efforts to get Russian President Vladimir Putin to negotiate an end to the war.

The London gathering, which included the leaders of Germany, France, Canada and other nations, did not produce a formal statement. But participants

SEE EUROPE ON A11

Russia reacts: Kremlin declares Trump "aligns with our vision." A11



KEVIN WINTER/GETTY IMAGES

A proud winner

Zoe Saldania accepts the best supporting actress Oscar for "Emilia Pérez" during the 97th Academy Awards in Hollywood on Sunday. See our coverage on C1 and C2 and at [washingtonpost.com/style](https://www.washingtonpost.com/style).

Three bald eagle eggs might be the charm

Calif. nest cam is eagerly watched for signs of life after heartbreak in 2024

BY ANGIE ORELLANA
HERNANDEZ

Jackie the bald eagle sensed it was time to give up even as her mate, Shadow, still held out hope.

The avian couple were entering a second year in a row without chicks. Jackie called out to Shadow urging him to let go as

he sat on their eggs for an extra three days in an apparent state of disbelief.

"He couldn't leave them alone," said Sandy Steers, a biologist and executive director of Friends of Big Bear Valley, a nonprofit that works in California's San Bernardino National Forest. "He had to sit."

Last year's heartbreaking

scene played across the United States as admirers of Jackie and Shadow tuned in daily to the live nest camera, waiting to see if the celebrity bald eagles' fortune would turn around. This year, it just might.

On Jan. 29, Friends of Big Bear Valley announced that Jackie had laid three eggs — a rare

SEE EGGS ON A7

IN THE NEWS

Israel blocks aid The nation said that it had stopped all assistance from entering the Gaza Strip, a move that threatened to plunge the territory back into a brutal war. A10

Ice rinks dwindling Minnesota officials say climate change is forcing them to reassess a cherished winter tradition. A8

THE NATION
The Education Department softened its stance on a policy proposal that said even race-neutral policies aimed at diversity could result in schools and universities losing federal funding. A2

A Trump order made English the nation's official language. A3
Current and former National Weather Service staffers said firings will harm the monitoring and prediction of weather hazards. A5

THE ECONOMY
The app Beeper can bring a measure of tidiness to your digital communications, Shira Ovide writes. A13

THE REGION
Jurisdictions across Northern Virginia are facing tough choices and much uncertainty this budget season. B1

A memorial performance at Capital One Arena in D.C. honored the skaters who died in January's aerial collision over the Potomac. B1
Maryland lawmakers have renewed a debate over charging juveniles as adults as they weigh a bill that aims to reduce such cases. B1

STYLE
At Strathmore, pianist Brian Ganz reached the penultimate chapter in his quest to perform the complete works of Chopin. C1
Many of the most memorable "MTV Unplugged" performances are now streaming on Paramount Plus. C4

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